

One table, one afternoon.



THE MEAL

Where
Date
Doors We eat at
Who is cooking
Who is hosting
Whose kitchen

THE COUNT Everything follows from it

Adults Children
No meat At the table

Turkey needed — about 1 lb (450 g) a head, 1½ for leftovers

WHO CANNOT EAT WHAT Ask on the invitation

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GETTING HERE Arrivals decide when the food goes out

WHO	ARRIVING	LEAVING

Two decisions, made today

First: **is it a potluck or is it not?** Half of the arguments about Thanksgiving are really about a guest who thought they were bringing something and a host who was already cooking it. Second: **what time do we eat?** Say it on the invitation. Everything on page 4 counts backwards from that hour.

Potluck? Told everyone

WHAT MAKES IT THANKSGIVING HERE

ORDERED, NOT BOUGHT The bird, the pies, the ice

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BORROWED — AND WHOSE IT IS

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The bird, worked out.

Date

2/9

FIND YOUR WEIGHT, TICK THE ROW

WEIGHT	METRIC	THAW	ROAST AT 325°F / 165°C
☐ 8 – 12 lb	3.5 – 5.5 kg	2 days	2¾ – 3 hrs
☐ 12 – 16 lb	5.5 – 7 kg	3 days	3 – 3¾ hrs
☐ 16 – 20 lb	7 – 9 kg	4 days	3¾ – 4½ hrs
☐ 20 – 24 lb	9 – 11 kg	5 days	4½ – 5 hrs

Guides, not laws: about 24 hours in the fridge for every 4–5 lb, and roughly 13 minutes a pound unstuffed. Stuffed adds about half an hour. A thermometer settles it, a clock does not.

SO, THE DATES Work backwards from the meal

Bird collected or delivered

Out of the freezer on

Thawed by

Brine or dry-brine from

Into the oven at

Out of the oven at

Rests until

Carved by

Still frozen on the morning?

Cold water, still in its wrapping, breast down: **30 minutes per pound**, and change the water every 30 minutes. Never warm water, and never left on the counter. Cook it straight afterwards rather than putting it back in the fridge.

The only number that decides whether it is cooked

165°F / 74°C in the thickest part of the thigh and of the breast, with the probe not touching bone. Colour, timing and the little plastic pop-up all lie. And **do not rinse the raw bird** — it does nothing except spray the sink and everything near it.

REST IT, PROPERLY Twenty to forty minutes

- ☐ Loosely covered with foil, not wrapped tight
- ☐ Somewhere the cats and the children are not
- ☐ The oven is now free — this is the plan on page 4
- ☐ Juices into the gravy while it rests

BEFORE THE DAY

- ☐ A meat thermometer that works, tested
- ☐ A tin the bird actually fits in
- ☐ Room in the fridge, cleared before it arrives
- ☐ Foil, string, and a rack or some onions
- ☐ Somewhere to put a hot tin down

NOT DOING A TURKEY? The weight and the method

Who is bringing what.



ASK FOR A DISH BY NAME _____			"Anything you like" gets you four bowls of the same thing		
WHO	WHAT THEY ARE BRINGING	COURSE	OVEN	COLD	HERE
_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
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_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐
_____	_____	_____	☐	☐	☐

The oven column is the whole point

A guest arriving with a casserole that needs forty minutes at 375°F, at the hour the turkey is resting and the potatoes are in, is the single most common way the meal runs late. Ask everyone whether their dish needs the oven, and put the ones that do onto page 4 **now**. Cold, room-temperature and stovetop dishes are the ones to ask for.



Write it first. Every line below counts back from this hour.

OFF THE OVEN ENTIRELY

Each one buys back an ...

DISH STOVE / COLD / SLOW COOKER

MADE THE DAY BEFORE

— Anything that reheats

THE LAST FIFTEEN MINUTES

- ☐ Gravy finished with the resting juices
- ☐ Plates and serving dishes warmed
- ☐ Someone carving, someone else pouring
- ☐ Everything cold brought out of the fridge

The shopping.



ORDER NOW, COLLECT LATER

WHAT	HOW MUCH	GOT
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CUPBOARD — BUY ANY TIME

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BUDGET

Planned _____ Spent _____

FRESH — THE LAST TWO DAYS

WHAT	HOW MUCH	GOT
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DRINK, AND SOMETHING FOR THE DRIVERS

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NOT FOOD, AND ALWAYS FORGOTTEN

- ☐ Foil, parchment, freezer bags
- ☐ Containers for the leftovers guests take home
- ☐ Ice — more than the fridge can make
- ☐ Bin bags, and somewhere for the recycling

The table, and who is at it.



WHERE EVERYONE SITS ————— Decide it now, not at the door

#	WHO	NEXT TO
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		
13		
14		
15		
16		
17		
18		

THE CHILDREN ————— Their own table, if enough

How many _____ Where _____

- ☐ Something for them to do before the food
 - ☐ Cups with lids, or cups they can spill
 - ☐ One adult who has agreed to sit there
- ON THE TABLE —————
- ☐ Enough chairs, counted, not assumed
 - ☐ Plates, cutlery and glasses — counted twice
 - ☐ Serving spoons, one per dish
 - ☐ Water on the table before anyone sits
 - ☐ Nothing tall in the middle; people want to see

THE ROUND OF THANKS ————— Short, and equal

Who starts _____ When _____

WHOEVER IS FINDING TODAY HARD —————

The three days before.



Two days before

☐ Fridge cleared, bird in it if it is not already

☐ Big shop done — everything except the fresh

☐ Chairs, plates and glasses counted

☐ Anyone who has not said what they are bringing, chased

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The day before

☐ Fresh shop, early

☐ Everything on the make-ahead list, made

☐ Table laid, or stacked ready to lay

☐ Bird out, patted dry, seasoned if you are dry-brining

☐ Read page 4 out loud to whoever is helping

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Thanksgiving morning

☐ Oven on early — it takes longer than you think

☐ Bird in at the time on page 2

☐ Coffee and something to eat, for the cooks

☐ Cold dishes out of the fridge in good time

☐ Dishwasher emptied before anyone arrives

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Carving	
Drinks	
Washing up	
The children	

- 1** Kitchen busy, guests elsewhere
One cook, one helper, a drink for both
- 2** Arrivals
Coats, a drink, and something to eat that is not the meal
- 3** Bird out of the oven
The oven is now free; page 4 takes over
- 4** Everything else in and out
Twenty minutes of noise, then it is done
- 5** Sit down
Say the time out loud an hour beforehand
- 6** The round of thanks
Before the food goes cold, not after
- 7** Eat
Nothing is being cooked now
- 8** Pudding, and a walk for whoever wants one
The plates can wait half an hour

- ☐ Containers filled — the list is on page 9
- ☐ Borrowed dishes back in their bags
- ☐ One photograph while everyone is still here

Friday.

Date

9/9

SENT HOME WITH PEOPLE

Fill them before people go

WHOWHATGONE

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TONIGHT, NOT TOMORROW

Two hours out, no more

- ☐ Meat off the bird and into the fridge
- ☐ Carcass into a pot or a freezer bag for stock
- ☐ Everything else boxed and labelled with the date
- ☐ Anything that will not be eaten in four days, frozen

BORROWED THINGS GOING BACK

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THE SECOND MEAL

Plan one, not five

THANK-YOUS

TO	FOR	SENT
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NEXT YEAR, IN THREE LINES

Worth ten in November

At the table

Bird was